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Culture (OWC): [Gusii \(FL08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1974-1976

Coverage Date: 1974-1976

Place Coverage

Morongo (a pseudonym), Southwestern Kenya, East Africa

Section Title(S)

SOME CHARACTERISTICS OF THE CASE MATERIAL

Within the constraints of enduring ambivalence, there was not a great deal of latitude for sexual fantasy. Traditions of puritanism and inhibition prevented these Gusii women from sharing their thoughts about such things. At first Trufena, the exception to so many rules, flaunted her sexuality before me and her mortified aunt, but this seemed to be the residue of courtship which, when relations with Ombui deteriorated, vanished precipitously and never reemerged, at least in my time. While Phoebe could say that in her girlhood she had craved sex, her current interest seemed substantially reduced. Four celibate months were no burden to her now. Sexual pleasure belonged, for a woman, to a short period of irresponsibility. At marriage a woman reordered her priorities. Sex became a serious business, the only means to the most important end of all. If at the same time as conceiving and bearing children a woman could prevent her husband from squandering on other women those economic resources which should be reserved for his family, she counted herself lucky. A wife had no real expectation of securing her husband's sexual fidelity as well as his financial support. Thus sex was a commodity in return for which a man could be urged to fulfill obligations of various sorts. The women worried about their side of the bargain and were concerned as to whether the benefits accruing to them would be in proportion to their own contribution. But if they fantasized about the pleasurable aspects of their commitment, they were for the most part extremely reticent in sharing their fantasies with me and, I believe, with other Gusii women as well. In certain circumstances [364](#) they could joke about sex in an impersonal, conventional manner, but rarely did they choose to speak about their own sexual experiences. There was a hysterical element about their attitude, as if they were disavowing any voluntary participation. As I came to know them better, the inhibitions they had about speaking of sexual matters in some cases relaxed a little, but for the most part they found it easier to talk about the social consequences of sex than the act itself.

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Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



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